

network as a whole. With a focus on being a decentralized global currency, Bitcoin developers have decided bitcoin transactions don't need all the bells and whistles. Instead, other developers can either find ways to build atop Bitcoin's limited functionality, turning to Bitcoin's blockchain as a system of record and means of security (e.g., Counterparty), or build an entirely different blockchain system (e.g., Ethereum).

Many were working on building this decentralized future on top of Bitcoin, but it wasn't easy. The flexibility in adding identifiers to addresses and creating different kinds of transactions was purposefully restricted in Bitcoin for the sake of scalability and security. Bitcoin, after all, was still an experiment. A decentralized currency was enough of a holy grail for Satoshi, and he didn't have to swallow the whole world in one bite. But Buterin wasn't satisfied with Bitcoin as it was and had wide-ranging aspirations for improvements. He wanted a system that was more flexible and that behaved more like a computer and less like a calculator for debits and credits of bitcoin balances.

Although he invented Ethereum in 2013, Buterin formally announced it in January 2014 at the North American Bitcoin Conference,⁸ where he was surrounded by eager reporters, many of whom had been his colleagues in months past. By that time, he had already garnered the support of over 15 developers and dozens in the community outreach team.⁹